

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: COLD OPEN, FABLE v0.2

2026-08-31. Written by a fresh Fable 5 subagent fed only the show framing, the five v1.2 verbatim, and Part G of the spine (v1.4). No file access, no repo, no memory. Fable has never seen Parts A to F and does not know which of the four, what was behind the door, or that anyone is alive. v0.2 is the same agent's cut of its own v0.1 (388 words) to the brief's cap, with the sergeant unnamed.

This is the candidate for the reader check. Two questions, ten minutes: does it grab you, do you believe it. Three readers, never one.

Checks: 329 words (pass, cap 330) · death and keys inside the first 70 words (pass) · no em dashes (pass) · nothing invented outside the brief (pass) · sergeant unnamed (pass; canon keeps Del's partnership unofficial) · sign-off "Goodnight, Harbour" carried from The Listener's close.

Timing: 2:12 at 150 wpm · 2:21 at 140 · 2:32 at 130. The death lands at about 0:15 and the keys at about 0:30.

For Stephen, not fixed: the brief said forty-five seconds to the death and the keys, and it meets that. It does not meet the FTUE's 35 to 40 second pre-play target (feature-ftue-onboarding-v1.md, still an open ruling); as Episode One this is a two-and-a-quarter-minute open, and the lesson from The Same House Twice stands: a mobile installer forty seconds after download has not chosen to listen. Where the first interaction goes against this open is a design ruling, not a prose note.

This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn.

Nine months ago, on a Monday night, Violet Moore died at the foot of her own stairs. She was forty-four. She painted letters for a living: shop fronts, boat names, once, for a bet, the side of a bus. There was a post-mortem. The coroner called it an accident.

Two weeks after she died, four people got a key in the post, and a letter in her hand. Liam Bryce. Ruby Walker. Margo Rivera. Brad Collins. The letter said she thought one of them was planning to kill her. She did not know which, and might be wrong. She told them not to go to the police, and why. What she had found was behind a door only the four of them could open.

They opened it together, on the Saturday. Behind it was a second letter. That one said she knew. Beside it, something of hers. The survivors won't say what.

Seven weeks after the funeral, Brad Collins drove to Kestrel Head and was never found. Five months later, Margo Rivera's car was in the same car park. Her body came into the harbour three days after that.

Liam Bryce and Ruby Walker each went to the police within the week. Not to accuse. To say: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her. A sergeant I trust in Harbor Ward told me they looked, properly, for six weeks. The letters are Violet's, lodged with her solicitor three weeks before she died, and the coroner's finding stands. They found nothing.

Now those two are taking each other apart on the front page of the Gazette, over a dead woman's letter. I wasn't there for any of it. Ruby has agreed to talk. Liam hasn't, yet. Before I record anyone, I'll ask them, on this microphone.

I don't know what the police couldn't find. But I'd like to sit with the people who loved her, and listen.

Goodnight, Harbour.

329 words.